

Sunnyside Ridge Road – Septic to Sewer Conversion Project Feasibility Report January 2025

Background

In January 2024 the SSRR Board discussed if there was an interest to pursue a project to convert the homes on SSRR from individual septic systems to a sewer connected to the LA County sewer system. Since the age of the septic systems are in excess of 60 years they would be increasingly at risk of needing to be repaired or replaced.

At the SSRR Annual Meeting in April the topic was discussed with the HOA members and it was agreed that a survey should be conducted to determine the interest of the members for a sewer conversion project.

A survey was conducted in May 2024 and the results indicated that 76% of respondents desired the Board to continue looking into sewer feasibility. A team of Rainer Otto, Renee Groskreutz and Mike Sarullo met with the Director of Public Works for Rancho Palos Verdes. This report summarizes the findings of the investigation.

Summary of Findings

It is not recommended that the HOA move forward with a project to convert from individual septic systems to a mainline sewer system connected to the County sewer system. The Team determined that a sewer conversion was not financially feasible for the homeowners on SSRR and would take more than four years to complete. A rough estimate of the cost of installing a new mainline sewer, each homeowner connecting to the sewer and then abandoning their septic system far exceeded the cost of replacing/repairing individual septic systems. The project would be complex and could suffer delays and be cancelled at various points.

Financial Estimates

The Director of Public Works provided a rough estimate of the total cost of \$10 million for installing the mainline sewer and plus the cost of all 57 homes connecting their individual sewers to the mainline sewer. The cost to each homeowner connecting the mainline sewer would vary on the length of the run and any additional cost for a pump if the homeowner system was at lower elevation than the connection point on the mainline. There would also be a one-time connection fee paid to County. This results in a cost of at least \$175,000/homeowner. With the cost of a full replacement of each septic system estimated to be around \$100,000 this results in a negative return for the project.

No external source of funding was identified. Thus construction of the mainline sewer project would have to be funded by setting up a new assessment district for SSRR community so that homeowners could be charged on the property tax bill to recover the cost over a typical 20-year recovery period. Activities before construction (Preliminary Engineering, Easements, Utility Clearance, Final Engineering, Permitting) would have to be funded by an assessment to HOA members.

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Note that there would not be a requirement for a homeowner to connect to the new sewer system. But each homeowner would be charged the assessment for constructing the new mainline sewer on their property tax bill whether they connect or not. If they connect to the sewer they would also be charged with an annual connection fee to pay for County Sewer operating costs.

Project Details

If this project would be undertaken it would be complex involving many agencies, require a number of permits and could be blocked from proceeding at various points.

Referring to the attached presentation, below is an overview of the process to plan and complete the project:

1. Preliminary Engineering-an engineering firm would need to be hired to assess the technical feasibility and prepare a draft design along with a cost estimate and schedule. In this activity the County Sewer authority would have to do a capacity study to determine if there is sufficient capacity to connect SSRR homeowners to the County System.
2. Easement- an SSRR homeowner(s) would have to agree to a ten-foot wide easement at the bottom of SSRR between 2208 and 2224 SSRR to connect to the County sewer system on Altaflora. The easement would have to be maintained to provide County vehicle access in case maintenance or repair would be required in the future. The easement would be documented in a signed agreement .
3. Utility Clearance-existing underground utilities would be identified and any points of interference identified. The design may have to be modified to resolve these.
4. Final Engineering-final plans are prepared and submitted to the City for review
5. Permitting-County permits (Sewer Connection Permit, Tap and Saddle Permit, Treatment & Disposal Permit); City (Encroachment Permit, Road Excavation Permit, Plumbing Permits, Septic Abandonment); other permits may be required.
6. Construction: either the HOA or an engineering firm must serve as a project manager to hire and oversee the construction firm. Construction will involve equipment staging, cutting up the street, steel plates, material staging, noise, along with sewer installation and traffic control.
7. Inspections will be conducted by County Public Works, City Public Works, and City Building & Safety
8. Abandonment of individual septic systems would involve removal of all wastes, destruction of the septic system, and backfill of septic system. Permits and inspections would be required.
9. Annexation - after construction is inspected and approved, ownership of the sanitary sewer system will be turned over to the City. The City will handle all future maintenance.

Recommendations

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The Board recommends that the septic to sewer conversion not be pursued any further at this time. It is recommended that each homeowner have their septic system periodically inspected and serviced.